lineage back to a founding matriarch or patriarch. All cats, for example, from the smallest house kitten to the most ferocious lion, share a common feline ancestor who lived about 25 million years ago.

Homo sapiens, too, belongs to a family. This banal fact used to be one of history's most closely guarded secrets. *Homo sapiens* long preferred to view itself as set apart from animals, an orphan who has no family, no cousins and – most importantly – no parents. But that's just not the case. Like it or not, we are members of a large and particularly noisy family called the great apes. Our nearest living relatives include chimpanzees, gorillas and orangutans. The chimpanzees are the closest. Just 6 million years ago, a single female ape had two daughters. One became the ancestor of all chimpanzees, the other is our own grandmother.

Skeletons in the Closet

Homo sapiens has kept hidden an even more disturbing secret. Not only do we possess an abundance of uncivilised cousins, once upon a time we had quite a few brothers and sisters as well. We are used to thinking about ourselves as the only humans, because for the last 10,000 years, our species has indeed been the only human species around. Yet the real meaning of the word human is 'an animal belonging to the genus *Homo*, and there used to be many other species of this genus besides *Homo sapiens*. Moreover, as we shall see in the last chapter of the book, in the not so distant future we might again have to contend with non-*sapiens* humans. To clarify this point, I will often use the term 'Sapiens' to denote members of the species *Homo sapiens*, while reserving the term 'human' to refer to all members of the genus *Homo*.

Humans first evolved in East Africa about 2.5 million years ago from an earlier genus of apes called *Australopithecus*, which means 'Southern Ape'. About 2 million years ago, some of these archaic men and women left their homeland to journey through and settle vast areas of North Africa, Europe and Asia. Since survival in the snowy forests of northern Europe required different traits than those needed to stay alive in Indonesia's steaming jungles, human populations evolved in different directions. The result was several distinct species, to each of which scientists have assigned a pompous Latin name.